Part A argument analysis: cram sheet

AP Seminar · end-of-course exam

Key ideas

1. **Order: A3, then A2, then A1.** A3 and A2 carry 12 of the 15 points; A1 is easy once A2 is done, so it goes last.
2. A3: one short qualified verdict, then specific evidence judged on relevance and credibility, each tied to its claim.
3. A2: explain how the claims connect to each other and to the whole argument; order is not connection.
4. A1: one or two sentences naming the whole thesis, not the topic.

A3: evidence (first)

6 points

Verdict	Mostly effective, partially successful, credible in some places but lacking in others, falls short, mostly ineffective. Match the passage.
How many	Practice target about 4 to 5 sources; no magic number, depth beats count. Source by source or grouped by shared problem.
Each piece	Evidence + the exact claim; relevance to that claim; credibility from what the passage gives; effect on confidence.
Judgment calls	Motives: could, may, might. Missing details mean credibility can't be established, not that the source is bad. Currency vs the article's date. Small samples can't carry broad claims.
Hard limit	Evaluating only sources, not their specific evidence, cannot score 6.

A2: line of reasoning (second)

6 points

Claims	Whole thesis = main claim; subclaims support it; a finding can be evidence and a subclaim.
Connections	Context, cause, extension, narrowing, qualification, objection, conclusion: say what each step does.
Pivots	Only if present; never invent a stage. Article order is the easiest default.
Shape	About 2 to 3 sentences opening, 2 on the pivot or condition, 1 conclusion. A model, not a quota.
Not here	Source critique belongs in A3.

A1: whole thesis (last)

3 points

Every part	Position, reason, any qualification, action and actor that the passage actually has.
Condense A2	The chain you just traced, in one or two sentences.
Topic only	Earns 1. Half the thesis earns about 2.

The timed write

about 30 min

min	do this (suggested split)
0 to 5	Quick read: whole thesis, important claims, evidence; mark T, C1, C2, E.
5 to 16	A3: verdict, then about 4 to 5 sources in depth.
16 to 26	A2: major claims with explicit links; end on the whole argument.
26 to 28	A1: the whole thesis.
28 to 30	Reread: complete sentences, nothing bulleted, no invented credentials.

Typed, complete sentences. Target 30, 35 at most once practiced; a first try may take 40 to 45. About 90 stays for Part B.

Templates (adapt to the passage)

A3 [Specific evidence] supports [claim] because [relevance or strength]. However, [real limit or missing detail] limits [what can be concluded], so it is [qualified judgment].

A2 In order to prove [main claim], [author] claims [specific claim], supports it with [evidence], showing [connection to another claim or the whole argument]. Later, the author shifts from [X] to [Y] to [explain connection]. Finally, [conclusion move] reinforces or qualifies [overall argument]. No real pivot? Skip the shift.

A1 [Author] argues that [position] because [main reason], and that [actor] should [action].

Scoring rules paraphrased from the College Board's AP Seminar end-of-course exam scoring guidelines (2026; consistent with 2025 Set 1). Order, source count and timing are study recommendations, not official limits. Abbreviations: AP, Advanced Placement; A1 to A3, Part A questions 1 to 3; C1, C2, claim 1, claim 2; T, thesis; E, evidence. valentinoguides.com/seminar-eoc-part-a